

A Register of Reconstructions

What the evidence shows, what Falkener supplies, and what is known now — for each of the three games.

Falkener's rules are not in the ancient sources. They are his, inferred from what survives, and the book presents them in the imperative with worked example games. This register separates the three layers for each game: what the evidence shows, what Falkener supplies, and what is known now.

It is not a correction. His reconstructions are careful, they produce playable games, and in 1892 nobody had tried. It is a reader's instrument, because the book itself does not mark where one layer ends and the next begins.

One thing this register does not do is score him. Reconstructing a lost game from a board and a handful of verses is legitimate scholarship, it is still how the subject proceeds, and the modern reconstructions rest on the same absence he was working in. What has changed since 1892 is not the evidence but the convention: a reconstruction is now published as one, with its assumptions on the page. Falkener published his as rules. The difference is presentational, and it is the only thing standing between this book and a modern one.

Tau, or the Game of Robbers (with the Roman *ludus latrunculorum*) · section IV

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Boards and men survive. Tomb paintings from the fourth dynasty onward show the game in play. The hieroglyphic name is read *sent*, written without a determinative and — Birch's own word — *very ambiguous*. On the Roman side, Latin poets refer to the *latrunculi*, the little robbers, and to pieces being blocked or surrounded.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

A complete ruleset: how pieces enter, how they move, how capture works by surrounding, and how the game is decided — followed by a full sample game in move notation played to a finish. He also identifies the Roman game as the Egyptian one carried west.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

The Egyptian game is what is now called **senet**, and its rules are still not known. Every published set, Falkener's included, is a reconstruction assembled from fragments spanning more than a thousand years of play that will have changed over them. The identification of the Roman game with the Egyptian is not what specialists hold today; *latrunculi* is treated as its own game.

Senat · section V

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

The same board with fewer pieces. Living practice in nineteenth-century Egypt, which Falkener reports at first hand: players scooping holes in the ground and using stones, beads or beans for men, called *kelbs* — dogs — the same word the Greeks used for the men in the game of robbers.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

A short game for two, with entry, movement, and capture by immediate successive takes; and the argument that a quick game must have existed alongside the long one because ordinary people do not play long games.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

The reasoning from social plausibility is sound as reasoning and is not evidence. The continuity he observes in the word *kelbs* is a genuine and interesting datum that survives independently of whether his rules are right. Capture by successive takes is the modern draughts convention, and its appearance here is Falkener's, not Egypt's.

Hab em Han, the Game of the Bowl · section VI

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

A spiral board of concentric rings with a bowl at the centre, shown in tomb scenes with spectators around it. Birch read the name over it as *hab em han*, the game of the jar. Falkener notes the board's resemblance to the circular labyrinth on the coins of Gnosus.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

Pieces enter two at a time by the throw of astragals; the bowl holds the stakes and the pieces that reach home; the winner is decided by how many pieces are brought home rather than by finishing first. He states plainly that *as it was a game for money, it was evidently played with dice*.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

This is the game modern Egyptology calls **mehen**, the coiled one, named for the serpent deity who encircles the sun god; it belongs to the Predynastic period and the Old Kingdom. Its rules are not known either. The best evidence is a scene in the tomb of Hesre at Saqqara showing the pieces that went with the board — lions, lionesses and sets of marbles — which is more than Falkener had and still not a ruleset.